

Your name:

The UK Linguistics Olympiad 2020

Round 2



Problem 3. A toad's miao (20 marks)

Below is a famous Miao folk tale, “The Pimpled Toad who was Wise,” written in the Large Flowery Miao language, which is spoken by about 300,000 people in Weining Autonomous County, Guizhou, China. Large Flowery Miao is generally written in two different scripts: either in the *Pollard* script, created in 1904 by the English missionary Samuel Pollard, or in Miao Pinyin, which uses Roman script. The version below is in the Pollard script.



Y⁻ ɛ_ɲ L^u L_n ɟ_u ɟ^u T^ɕ.

ɕ_ɕ ɲ_n ɟ_u T^u Lⁿ Y⁻ ɟ_u ɕɛ^r T^u ɛ_ɲ L^u L_n. T^u Lⁿ Y⁻ ɲ_n, ɛ_ɲ,
ɟ^u ɲ⁻ ɕ^u ɕ_ɕ ɕɲⁱ. T^u Y⁻ ɛ_ɲ ɲ_n, ɕ_ɕ ɲ⁻ ɟ^u ɕɲⁱ, V^{nc} ɟ^u ɕɲⁱ
Y⁼ T⁻ T_{nc}. ɕ_ɕ ɕ⁻ ɲ⁻ ɕ^u ɟ^u ɕɲⁱ, ɲ⁻ ɲ⁻ ɟ^u ɲ⁻ ɕɲ^u, L^u ɕɲ^u ɲⁿ,
L^u Y⁻ ɕɲ^u ɟ_u Y^u, ɕ^ɕ Y^u ɲ_u ɕ^u T^u ɟ^u ɕɲⁱ. T^u Lⁿ Y⁻ ɕⁿ T⁻,
ɛ_ɲ ɟ^u ɲ⁻ ɕ^u ɕ_ɕ ɕɲⁱ L_i. T^u Lⁿ Y⁻ ɕ^ɕ L^u Lⁿ ɲ^u T^u ɲⁿ ɟ⁻
ɲ_o ɲ_u ɲ_u. T^u ɛ_ɲ ɲ^{nc} ɲ^u ɟ_u L^u ɟ_u Y^u L_u.
T^u Lⁿ Y⁻ ɕ_ɕ Y^u ɕ^ɕ, T^u ɛ_ɲ, ɕ^ɕ, ɲⁿ T^u. T^u Lⁿ Y⁻ Lⁿ ɟ_u ɕ^ɕ
Lⁿ ɲ^u T⁻ ɲ_n, Y⁻ Y⁻, ɟ_u L⁻ L⁻, Y⁻ Y⁻, ɟ_u L⁻ L⁻.

The next version is an English translation of the “The Pimpled Toad.” Of course, not every word in the English translation has an equivalent word in Miao; on the other hand, some English words may be translated by more than one Miao word. Also, note that constructions of the

Your name:

The UK Linguistics Olympiad 2020

Round 2



form “I want to eat you / you want to eat me” are written in Miao as “I want to eat your flesh / you want to eat my flesh.”

The Pimpled Toad that was Wise.

They say that a crow went to meet a pimpled toad. The crow said, “Toad, I want to eat you.” The toad said, “You want to eat me, but my flesh is very bitter. If you want to eat me, you want to carry me over there, to the stream, to the bank of the pool of water. Wash me in water, then eat to get my flesh.” The crow replied, “Toad, I want to eat you, so there!” The crow stretched his head upwards, laughing *ha-ha*. The toad jumped, hopped down to the pool water, and was gone. The crow waded in the water to seek the toad, sought him, but did not get him. The crow simply stretched his head, cawed, and said, “Ah-ah, all for nothing! Ah-ah, all for nothing!”

Finally, here is the Miao Pinyin transcription. However, there are some changes:

- The sentences, including the title, are in random order.
- Five of the sentences have been divided into two parts.
- Punctuation has been removed.
- The numbered blanks (e.g. 18) mark places where one or more words are missing.

A. tái <u>1</u> jỳ áo "trīeh tái jìeu "trīeh hì táo	J. <u>10</u> bí-xá dlò hà-hà
B. jỳ <u>2</u> yā nǎo gū "ghǎi yā drìh gū dlá "drũ	K. tái jìeu tlíe tlw̄ bào lái <u>11</u> áo lèu
C. tú <u>3</u> jī-tá jìeu	L. tái lí-á lí-mù <u>12</u> lí-fáo ghá hì
D. gū yā nǎo jỳ "ghǎi <u>4</u>	M. á á <u>13</u> bè-lá-lá
E. tú lí-á <u>5</u> jìeu	N. tái lí-á <u>14</u> lái lí-fáo
F. gū yā nǎo jỳ "ghǎi	O. tái á-jìeu hì jỳ <u>15</u> nǎo gú <u>16</u>
G. nỳ hì gù tú lí-á <u>6</u> "jīh tái jìeu lú-lì	P. víe gū "ghǎi íeh tá-tìe
H. "zā <u>7</u> drài <u>8</u> táo gū "ghǎi	Q. lái <u>17</u> lái á-"tú bào áo
I. á-jìeu lú-lì <u>9</u> báo-táng	

See the notes and the question on the next page.

Your name:

The UK Linguistics Olympiad 2020

Round 2



Notes

- The diacritics (accent marks) ´, ` , ¯, ~ written over vowels represent tones
- *ieh* and *w* are vowels/vowel sequences
- *gh*, *dl*, *tl*, *dr*, and *tr* are consonants
- *n* (e.g. *ⁿt*) marks nasalization of the following consonant, that is, air flow escapes through the nose and the mouth simultaneously during the production of the consonantal sound.

Q3. On your answer sheet, write the word or words missing from gaps 1-17.